

BANDEEP SINGH

wares of mobile accessories on a bench in the Bhopal House Park. Tripathi's target customers are the visitors to the Sharma Tea House in the vicinity. He makes Rs 400-500 a day selling mobile covers, headphones and chargers. This is not the job Tripathi had hoped for when he finished BCom in 2019 from the Lucknow Christian College. But then his father had to shut down their photo studio during the pandemic and it fell on him to support the family. Juggling his tiny business, Tripathi appeared for the Staff Selection Board exams, but did not get through. He is now preparing for the state Police Recruitment Board examinations but is unsure if the selection process will begin anytime soon.

Tripathi listened to the finance minister's speech with mixed feelings. The upside for him was her announcement that customs duty cut on inputs for mobile phone manufacturing could spur phone sales, benefiting his business. But he felt she could have done more on the jobs front. "Government jobs are the only attraction among the youth from poor families like me," he says. "We hope the big allocations made for various government schemes will improve our job prospects."

Mahesh Vyas, the MD and CEO of CMIE, who has tracked employment for long, puts the problem of youth like Tripathi in perspective. "Youngsters who are just out of college with no experience remain at a big disadvantage," he says. "They are not willing to work at a lower wage as it can ruin their careers and struggle to get a good job. A large number give themselves till age 30 for a government job. Then they give up and settle for a low wage job."

BIDING HER TIME

BA in English
Current status: Gives tuitions

DIKSHA KUMARI, 23
Patna, Bihar

A resident of Bangaon village in Bihar's Saharsa district, Diksha Kumari completed her BA in 2021 with 66 per cent marks. For the past three years, she has been applying for government jobs and attending coaching classes for exams, to no avail. Diksha feels it's not clear from the latest budget whether the government has a plan to improve the employment scenario. Even if it does, it may have been presented with just elections in mind, she says. Hailing from a lower middle class family, she wants to get a job soon to help her father, who works in a private company, and is the sole breadwinner in the family. Her dream is to appear for the civil service examinations, but she says it is not easy to live in Patna for over two years looking for a job as the expenses are high. Currently, she is making some additional money by giving tuition lessons.

"I AM NOT SURE IF THIS BUDGET HAS ANY SPECIFIC PLANS TO INCREASE EMPLOYMENT OPPORTUNITIES"

– Pushyamitra